

Just in case

Overview This paper focuses on the meaning of *in case*-conditionals (ICCs). We show that ICCs differ from *if*-conditionals in two respects. First, ICCs are obligatorily interpreted as biscuit conditionals, while *if*-conditionals also have hypothetical readings (1). Second, ICCs are infelicitous when their antecedent is entailed by the common ground (2a), while *if*-conditionals are compatible with these factual readings even under their biscuit interpretation (2b).

- (1) a. In case you're thirsty, there's beer in the fridge.
b. #In case John remembered to go to the liquor store, there's beer in the fridge.
- (2) a. A: I'm feeling a bit thirsty.
B: #In case you're thirsty, there's some lemonade in the fridge.
b. A: I'm feeling a bit thirsty.
B: If you're thirsty, there's some lemonade in the fridge.

We sketch a dynamic analysis of ICCs that treats them as conditional assertions and derives the contrast in (2a).

ICCs are always biscuits We start by showing that ICCs are obligatory biscuits. (i) Like assertoric biscuit conditionals, assertoric ICCs entail their consequents:¹

- (3) a. In case you're thirsty, there's beer in the fridge. $\Rightarrow$ There's beer in the fridge.
b. If you're thirsty, there's beer in the fridge. $\Rightarrow$ There's beer in the fridge.

As Rawlins (2020) points out, consequent entailment is not a sufficient condition for characterizing biscuits: unconditionals (Rawlins, 2013) and concessive conditionals (Bennett, 1982) also entail their consequents. However, ICCs are morphosyntactically distinct from unconditionals and, unlike concessive conditionals, ICCs cannot be modified by *even*:

- (4) a. Even if John does a good job, he will be fired at the end of the year.
b. (*Even) In case you're hungry, there are biscuits in the cupboard.

(ii) Like biscuit conditionals, ICCs cannot be modified by *only* (Geis and Lycan, 1993) (iii) nor can they be embedded under attitude verbs (Bhatt and Pancheva, 2006) – (5a) and (5b) only have (pragmatically odd) hypothetical readings. Since these readings are unavailable for the ICCs in (6a) and (6b), they are infelicitous.

- (5) a. Only if you're thirsty, there's beer in the fridge. $\checkmark_{\text{HYP}}, \times_{\text{BIS}}$
b. John believes that if you're thirsty, there's beer in the fridge. $\checkmark_{\text{HYP}}, \times_{\text{BIS}}$

- (6) a. #Only in case you're thirsty, there's beer in the fridge.
b. #John believes that in case you're thirsty, there's beer in the fridge.

(iv) *In case*-clauses cannot serve as the restrictors of quantifiers, which, as noticed by Bhatt and Pancheva (2006) is a distinctive feature of biscuit conditionals.

- (7) a. If a student fails the exam, he usually tries again. (Moltmann, 2019)
b. #In case a student fails the exam, he usually tries again.

¹We restrict the generalization to assertoric biscuit conditionals, because conditional questions and conditional imperatives may also be biscuits. In these cases, biscuit conditionals fail to entail their consequent for the simple reason that the usual notion of entailment no longer is applicable.

Proposal Following a prominent analysis of biscuit conditionals, we suggest an analysis of ICCs as conditional speech acts (Iatridou, 1991; DeRose and Grandy, 1999; Siegel, 2006; Krifka, 2014). We argue that, in a conditional of the form ‘in case p, q ’, the *in case*-clause serve to highlight the p -possibilities in the common ground, while the consequent asserts q . Following Starr (2014), we treat *information states* $s = \langle c, h \rangle$ as pairs consisting of a *context set* c (the worlds consistent with all the propositions that are common ground) and a *highlighted set* h (the set of worlds in c that the interlocutors are currently attending to). The effect of asserting ‘in case p ’ is two-fold: first, it tests whether the context set c is consistent with p ; if it is, the p -worlds are added to the highlighted set. An update with an ICC is illustrated schematically in Figure 1.

$$(8) \langle c, h \rangle[\text{in case } p, q] = \begin{cases} \langle c \cap q, (p \cap c) \cap q \rangle & \text{if } c[p] \neq \emptyset \\ \emptyset & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

In contrast, the *if*-clause of a biscuit conditional simply tests whether the antecedent is compatible with c , but does not add the antecedent proposition to h .

$$(9) \langle c, h \rangle[\text{if}_{\text{BISCUIT}} p, q] = \begin{cases} \langle c \cap q, h \cap q \rangle & \text{if } c[p] \neq \emptyset \\ \emptyset & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

The contrast in (2) arises then due to the highlighting effect of ICCs; in (2a), this results in a redundant update because the worlds in c where A is thirsty have already been made salient.

The *in-case/might* connection In our semantics, *in case*-clauses function much like the modal *might* functions in the attentional semantics of Ciardelli et al. (2009). This strikes us as a welcome prediction, because ICCs can often be paraphrased as *since*-clauses that contain an epistemic possibility modal:

- (10) a. In case you’re thirsty, there’s beer in the fridge.
 b. $\approx$ Since you might be thirsty, there’s beer in the fridge.

Moreover, like ICCs, *since+might*-clauses are also infelicitous when their prejacent is already entailed by the common ground (11).

- (11) a. A: I’m feeling a bit thirsty.
 B: #Since you might be thirsty, there’s some lemonade in the fridge.

In contrast, ordinary *since*-clauses pattern with the *if*-clauses of ordinary biscuit conditionals and remain felicitous when entailed by the common ground:

- (12) a. A: I’m feeling a bit thirsty.
 B: Since you’re thirsty, there’s some lemonade in the fridge.

This, we believe, supports our hypothesis that ordinary biscuit conditionals closely resemble *in case*-conditionals, but lack the highlighting effect of ICCs.

Outlook The main empirical contribution of this paper is the observation that ICCs are obligatory biscuits. To our knowledge, this is the first evidence of unambiguous, morphologically-marked biscuitness in the literature. Because ICCs disambiguate between hypothetical and biscuit readings, they promise to be a fruitful testing ground for theories of biscuit conditionals.

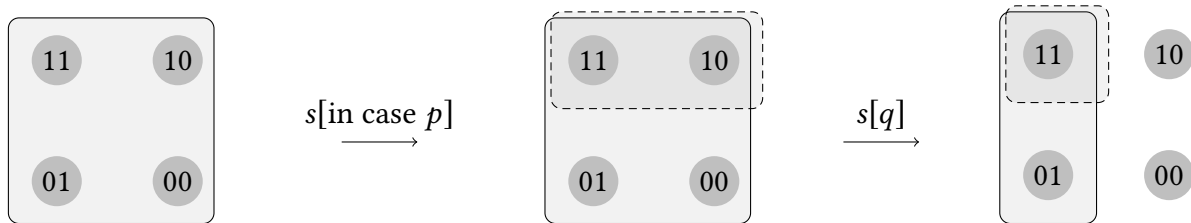


Figure 1: Updating with ‘in case p, q ’

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